

Caring - Rabbi Perl's Guide to Caregiving

The Gift of Being a Caregiver

There are three groups affected by illness: the patient, the caregiver, and the family. In many ways, the caregiver is really a hidden patient.

The role of caregiver is certainly not one we request. Undoubtedly, it is a very daunting and challenging responsibility. It is normal, for any caregiver to initially feel very overwhelmed.

At the same time, it is a sublime opportunity that involves the lofty mitzvah of emulating G-d's ways of caring and compassion.

The Responsibilities of the Caregiver

If you are a caregiver for a parent, then at every moment, you are also fulfilling the 5th commandment of honoring your father and mother. This commandment includes feeding them, giving them to drink, & helping them get dressed. These are all duties of a caregiver.

If you are a husband caring for a wife, you are living up to the commitment you made to her in the ketubah, the Jewish marriage document, where you pledged that you will cherish, feed, and support her. When caring for a spouse, be careful to reassure them that they are not a burden and are very much loved.

The Welfare of the Caregiver

It's an understatement to say that caregivers have a lot on their plates: Your welfare as a caregiver is very important. Therefore, you should not hesitate to accept outside help and delegate responsibilities whenever possible.

Do what it takes to maintain proper eating and sleeping habits in order to have strength to care for your loved ones.

Be careful not to neglect your spouse and/or children when caregiving and consult with a knowledgeable spiritual advisor whenever necessary to find a correct balance.

The Art of a Caring Caregiver

The mental health of the patient is of paramount importance.

Therefore, it is important to consider whether or not the patient needs to know the specifics of his diagnosis; to choose a doctor with a positive outlook and good bedside manner; help the patient experience pleasure despite his compromised condition; to implement effective pain management. A successful caregiver also includes ensuring the patient receives proper nutrition.

If the patient feels 'controlled' by the caregiving spouse, it might be necessary to bring in others to help.

The Caregivers and End-of-Life Challenges

It is important to choose a doctor who shares your values regarding end-of-life issues.

Decisions of healthcare professionals are frequently in contrast to Torah Jewish values. DNR (Do Not Resuscitate); DNI (Do Not Intubate); DNT (Do Not Treat) all depends on the situation, which is why it is crucial to work with and trust both the doctor and a designated rabbinical advisor of Jewish medical law and ethics.

This Jewish Health Care Living Will has the advantage of including the name of a rabbi to be consulted to help the proxy make the correct Jewish medical and ethical decisions.

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The Gratitude of the Caregiver

When we remember that everything is from G-d and for good, and that everything is in His hands, we take on our challenges without regret or self-pity.

This awareness also allows us to relate to those to whom we give care, with true love and respect, knowing that they are not an external burden or a coincidence that happened to fall into life, but rather an important, intrinsic part of our life, the life that G-d is supervising with love and kindness. Yes, we the caregiver, the patient and G-d are partners in this together.

The Caregivers Own Gift of Health

We must always remember that our own Divine gift of health does not make us superior to those who have the challenges of illness

Let us remember to use our gifts to develop gratitude for all that we have and don't have, and to help all those who we can. Let us open our eyes and our hearts, and be grateful for the ability and the opportunity to care and to help.

People Are Not Vegetables

It has become common practice to call people without obvious consciences "vegetables". What does this mean? Did the persons hands, legs, heart and brain they used for years, now convert to some tiny leaves, roots, seeds or merely chlorophyll now?

And the soul of the ill person has become the life force of a vegetable no different than that of a potato? The Soul, that is part of G-d, that is part of the Infinite, is the essence of life. Are we to believe that the soul has lost its holiness because of an accident or illness?

We Are the Invisible Caregivers

Have you ever fantasized about being invisible, going about your day without being seen or noticed? Try being a caregiver. Caregivers don't make headlines; they perform their duties unnoticed, silently, imperceptible and voiceless to most of society. They are the quiet, unassuming heroes.

If you're reading this and you are not a caregiver, but know of someone who could use a few minutes of your time, please help them.

Please be patient and compassionate; caregivers desperately need understanding and gentle loving-kindness, not lectures or criticism.

Calm Nerves with a Calming Chapter of Psalms

The Lubavitcher Rebbe, Menachem M. Schneerson of sainted memory, gives the following advice:

...Study chapter 23 of the Book of Psalms, until you are well versed in it. Recite this chapter on the Sabbath, Monday and Thursday and give several coins to charity before lighting Shabbat candles and you will merit (as stated in the above chapter) that 'G-d is with you' & 'only goodness and kindness will follow you'.

Consequently no one at all can have power over you at all.

